

A PARENT'S REFLECTION. A STUDENT'S NEXT STEPS.

If I could go back in time...

What I wish I'd understood before my children started high school—and what you can do now.

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01

What I wish I'd understood

I have two children who are now high school seniors. I've spent many evenings helping them finish assignments, but much less time helping them connect today's choices to tomorrow's possibilities.

If I could start again, I'd help them explore earlier, understand their academic choices, and build a relationship with their counselor. I'd want them to have more options, more confidence, and more room to discover where they might thrive.

02

Start with you

You don't need to choose a career or a dream college in ninth grade. Start by noticing what interests you and what helps you learn.

Do you enjoy hands-on projects? A busy city or a smaller town? Competition or collaboration? Which subjects and problems make you curious?

Your answers can change. That's discovery.

Start with the student. Explore places that fit.
Then work backward to what you can do now.

03

Change the question

From chasing rankings to preparing for a place where you can thrive

Instead of starting here...	Try asking...
What's the best college I can get into?	Where could I learn, grow, and thrive?
Where do I rank as an applicant?	What preparation would help me pursue a school that fits?
Which schools should I apply to?	What can I do now to expand my future options?
How do I improve my odds?	How do I build several promising pathways?

Keep a portfolio of possibilities.
Explore several interests, environments, programs, and schools. Narrow thoughtfully as you learn, without reducing your future to one perfect destination.

Keep exploring. Start preparing.

Build a plan you can revise as you learn more about yourself.

EXPLORE · DISCOVER · PREPARE · REFINE

01
Explore
Try subjects, activities, and learning environments.

02
Discover
Notice your interests, strengths, and preferences.

03
Prepare
Connect promising options to courses and experiences.

04
Refine
Review with your counselor. Adjust your next steps.

Return to exploration as interests change. These are recurring steps, not fixed grade-level deadlines.

04

Your next moves

1. **Keep a possibilities list.** Save programs, schools, experiences, and questions that interest you. Add why each one appeals.
2. **Check the preparation.** Look at courses, prerequisites, and relevant experiences. Ask what choices could keep doors open.
3. **Choose a few actions.** Pick something useful for this semester: try an activity, visit a different environment, or talk with someone in a field you're curious about.
4. **Review and revise.** What did you enjoy? What surprised you? Update the plan when your interests or circumstances change.

Exploration and preparation belong together. You can keep your interests open while unintentionally narrowing academic options. Grades and curriculum strength matter in admissions.[1] Ask about course sequences early.

05

Make your counselor a partner

My children's high school principal told me that, with a magic wand, she'd replicate an exceptional college and career counselor so every student could have sustained, individual guidance starting in ninth grade.

Counselors bring expertise, but their time is stretched. The national ratio was 372 students per counselor in 2024–25, across all grade levels; ASCA recommends 250:1.[2]

Bring three things to your next meeting

- A few interests or possible directions.
- Your current courses and upcoming choices.
- Two or three questions about what to do next.

Ask: *What am I missing? Which prerequisites matter? What's one useful next step?*

A note for parents

Keep conversations low-pressure. Understand upcoming course choices, help make opportunities visible, and support the counselor relationship. Offer help without taking over. Measure progress by clarity, preparation, and confidence—not prestige.

You don't need every answer now.

Keep learning about yourself. Keep preparing. Keep meaningful options open.

Sources: 1. NACAC, Factors in the Admission Decision (Fall 2023 survey). 2. ASCA, School Counselor Roles & Ratios (2024–25).

Further exploration: Project Jarvis is my early exploration of AI-assisted college planning that supports students, parents, and counselors. Read the Jarvis reference in the full essay.